

Exercise 4: Develop an end-of-life (EOL) plan for the scenario

Part I: Review the EOL planning format

EOL planning category	Planning considerations
Product identification	• The product or product line name is documented • Documentation includes Product ID/SKU information and so on • The impact on the Product Mix is understood
Rationale	• The rationale for product retirement is defined • Retirement process is defined
Retirement strategy	• Retirement strategy is defined • Options to include divest, spin-off, harvest, or retirement are justified
Proposed mitigation plan	• The retirement process is mapped • The process is shared and understood
Communications planning	• Define how the retirement process will be communicated
Internal impact	• Manufacturing and operations considerations are addressed • Customer support considerations are addressed • Sales and support considerations are addressed • Human Resource and legal considerations are addressed • Legal and regulatory considerations are addressed
External impact	• External customer and partner support considerations are addressed • Customer support considerations are addressed
Cost analysis	• Cost/Benefit analysis is performed • Define approval process
Scheduling	• Retirement activity schedules are developed • Schedules are realistic and achievable
Risk analysis	• Risks are identified and qualified • Contingency responses are developed
Critical success factors (CSF)	• CSF are identified • A CSF measurement plan is developed

Part II: End-of-life (EOL) plan blank template

EOL planning category	Planning considerations
Product identification	• Product Name: Mobile Laptop Interface Whiteboard – Model WB-3000 • Product Category: Portable interactive whiteboard + laptop stand • SKU/Product ID: Assigned internally as <i>WB-3000</i> • Product Mix Impact: ○ Adds to existing LWT whiteboard portfolio (traditional, portable, children’s boards). ○ Retirement will align with planned obsolescence strategy—product replaced with updated version after two years. ○ Inventory, parts, warranty processes tied into overall whiteboard product line.
Rationale	• Technology in the interactive whiteboard market evolves rapidly; obsolescence is expected within two years. • Planned obsolescence strategy approved by CEO. • Cost/benefit analysis shows maintaining product beyond three years results in more cost than benefit. • Replacement model will leverage current design and technology improvements (spin-off model). • Ensures LWT stays competitive while mitigating customer dissatisfaction through transparency and incentives.
Retirement strategy	• Strategy: Spin-off replacement model introduced after two years. • Retirement will be phased out gradually over one year. • Customers receive incentives to upgrade, including discounts and early notification. • All warranties and contracts honoured through the retirement period. • Retirement communication begins 6 months prior to replacement launch. • Old product fully depreciated at Launch + 24 months.
Proposed mitigation plan	• Clear, early customer communication to avoid surprise or dissatisfaction. • Provide incentives (discounts) for customers to transition to the updated model. • Maintain parts inventory and repair capability throughout retirement period. • Legal team ensures all contractual obligations are managed and compliant. • Create an issues management hotline for potential problems. • Provide thorough documentation and FAQs for transitioning users.

Communications planning	• Six-month advance notifications sent to all customers (email, site notice, reseller communication). • Launch a dedicated EOL webpage explaining timelines, transition options, and incentives. • Sales reps briefed to guide customers through upgrade options. • Public announcement coordinated with marketing and PR teams. • Internal communications to Customer Support, Operations, and Sales for alignment. • Press release and social announcements timed with the replacement product reveal.
Internal impact	• Manufacturing/Operations: ○ Ramp down production nearing the 24-month mark. ○ Plan for parts inventory throughout retirement. ○ Update documentation and manuals for replacement model. • Customer Support: ○ Maintain help desk and FAQ for existing WB-3000 customers. ○ Prepare troubleshooting for end-of-life period. ○ Ensure smooth warranty/repair handling. • Sales and Marketing: ○ Prepare materials explaining upgrade path and incentives. ○ Adjust sales targets for the new replacement model. • Human Resources & Legal: ○ Legal ensures compliance with contractual obligations. ○ HR ensures internal staff training for replacement product knowledge.
External impact	• External customers receive upgrade discounts, support, and full warranty coverage. • Partners (Amazon, Walmart, trade shows) notified 6 months prior. • Distributors updated with inventory phase-out timeline. • Corporate/educational contracts honoured until end of coverage. • User groups and influencers informed to avoid confusion when replacement launches.
Cost analysis	• Retirement administrative costs: communication, legal review, support escalation. • Incentive costs: discounts on replacement model for existing customers. • Inventory and parts management during retirement window. • Cost/benefit analysis supports retirement due to diminishing returns after year 3. • Approval process led by Product Manager, Finance, Operations, and CEO.

Scheduling	• Current date: February 20XX • Replacement communication begins: Launch + 18 months • Full transition/retirement: Launch + 24 months • One-year phase-out period • Schedules verified as realistic and aligned with operational capacity • Issues management hotline established during retirement window
Risk analysis	• Identified risks: • Customer dissatisfaction or surprise • Slow transition to new model • Supply chain shortages impacting replacement availability • Contractual issues with partners • Contingency responses: • Advance communication (6+ months) • Incentive offers for upgrade • Emergency parts inventory reserves • Legal continuous monitoring • Dedicated hotline to resolve issues quickly
Critical success factors (CSF)	• Successful customer transition rate to the new model • Minimal customer dissatisfaction (goal: <3% negative feedback) • Warranty claims handled without delays • Effective communication across all customer segments • Replacement model launch on time • Smooth inventory phase-out with minimal waste • Metrics tracked via customer feedback, support tickets, and upgrade conversions